

Gretser LA-EN

Defensio Controversiarum Bellarmini — Felix II and Liberius: recognition legitimates a pope

by Jakob Gretser, S.J. (1562–1625); *Defensio of Bellarmine's Controversies, Tomus II (De Christo et Pontifice Romano)*, Ingolstadt 1609 (= *Opera omnia*, tomus IX)

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- Latin transcribed complete (no elisions) from the page images of the Ingolstadt 1609 edition: cols. 1050–1051 (PDF pp. 576–577), col. 532 (PDF p. 309), and col. 1242 (PDF p. 673). Long-s and u/v normalized, abbreviations silently expanded, original spelling otherwise retained; italics mark the adversaries' quoted words.
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- Version: 1.1 (complete passages)
- Selection pages: Tom. II, cols. 531–532, 1050–1051, 1242

Note on this selection: recognition-legitimation applied to a pope, defended against the Protestant controversialists Whitaker, Sutcliffe, and Junius. Felix II entered by an election Gretser concedes was vitiosus — an Arian-backed intrusion while Liberius lived, which the Roman clergy at first refused under oath (“that, while Liberius lived, they would receive no other” — the acceptance-refusal that kept an intruder from the title). When Liberius fell into the external appearance of heresy, the recognition reversed: Felix “was acknowledged and openly held as legitimate Pontiff,” and “from that time Felix was MADE legitimate Pope... and remained true Pontiff to the end of his life.” Note the complete passage's two-school structure on the privately-heretical pope: those who admit a pope can privately err simply concede Liberius's fall; those who deny it resolve the case entirely in the external forum — a pope can be declared deposed “also on account of the EXTERNAL APPEARANCE of heresy... for men are not bound to, nor can they, search hearts, but him whom they see by external works to be a heretic, they judge simply a heretic.” Either way the title travels with the Church's public recognition: the papal twin of Bellarmine's De Conciliis II.9 rule (“whatever may lie hidden in their hearts”) and a seventeenth-century anticipation of the intention-of-the-elect argument — no interior state, of elector or elect, can defeat the public constitution of the title. Gretser thus witnesses the cause-version of the fact-guarantee two decades before Castro Palao's sanatio. The third passage completes the picture: even the schismatic emperors venerated their antipopes “as Vicars of Christ” — conceding the office itself while mistaking its

occupant — and Junius’s rejoinder (all such witness “must be ascribed to public error and inveterate custom”) is the standing Protestant objection every acceptance-argument must answer, preserved here with Gretser’s riposte. Classification: School 1 (cause; note unassigned).

Cols. 1050–1051 (PDF pp. 576–577) — Felix, Liberius, and Whitaker’s “insoluble knot”

<i>Latin (1609)</i>	<i>English</i>
Ait Bellarminus, Felicem non fuisse legitimum Pontificem usque ad lapsum Liberij. Hoc Iunio incredibile videtur. <i>Quis enim credat, inquit, Liberium aut noluisse, aut non prospexisse Ecclesiae Romanae prius de Episcopo, quàm, persequente Constantio, fugeret?</i> citatque pro se antiquissimum auctorem <i>Fasciculi Temporum</i>, qui est centum et paucorum insuper annorum, cuius testimonio constare dicit; Felicem, factum Romanum Episcopum de Liberij consensu. At omnes veteres reclamant: qui per vim et violentiam ab Arianis Felicem intrusum dicunt; tantumque abesse videtur, ut Liberius sibi successorem dari, et se hac dignitate abdicare, voluerit, ut quidquid fecit, id cupiditate suae sedis recuperandae fecisse non immerito existimari queat, et adeo clerus Romanus non consensit initio in Liberium, ut iureiurando se adstrinxerit, se vivente Liberio, nullum alium recepturum. Sed ex his nectit nobis Witackerus nodum insolubilem, ut ipse quidem arbitratur. Ita enim nos premit. <i>Papistae defendunt, Pontificem non posse abdicari, nisi propter haeresin in Concilio damnatum</i> (non disquiram, quàm verè hoc Witackerus asserat. Legatur Bellarminus supra lib. 2. cap.	Bellarmino says that Felix was not legitimate Pontiff until the lapse of Liberius. This seems incredible to Junius. <i>For who would believe</i>, he says, <i>that Liberius either refused, or failed to provide the Roman Church with a Bishop before he fled from the persecuting Constantius?</i> — and he cites for himself the very ancient author of the <i>Fasciculus Temporum</i> (who is all of a hundred and a few years old), by whose testimony he says it is established that Felix was made Roman Bishop with the consent of Liberius. But all the ancients cry out against this: they say Felix was intruded by force and violence by the Arians; and so far does it seem from being the case that Liberius wished a successor to be given him and to abdicate this dignity, that whatever he did may not unreasonably be judged to have been done from the desire of recovering his see; and so little did the Roman clergy at first consent to [Felix], that they bound themselves by oath that, while Liberius lived, they would receive no other. But from these things Whitaker ties us a knot insoluble — as he himself, at any rate, reckons. For he presses us thus: <i>The Papists maintain that a Pontiff cannot be deposed except when condemned for heresy in a Council</i> (I shall not inquire how truly Whitaker asserts this; let Bellarmine be read above, book 2, chapter 30); <i>but Liberius was deposed; therefore</i>

<i>Latin (1609)</i>	<i>English</i>
30.) <i>abdicatus autem fuit Liberius, ergo in haeresin incidit, pugnat igitur secum adversarius, inquit Calvinista, cum fatetur abdicatum fuisse, et tamen negat fuisse haereticum. Respondeo, qui defendunt Pontificem, ut privatam personam, posse incidere in haeresin, et Liberium reipsa in Haeresin incidisse: uno Spiritu Witackerianam obiectionem diffiant: Qui verò negant, Pontificem, etiam ut privatum doctorem, incurrere posse in haeresin, atque adeo Liberium ab omni haereseos interno actu liberant; Respondebunt, non propter solam haeresin manifestam, veram et realem, Pontificem deponi posse; vel potius à Deo deponi, et postea ab Ecclesia iudicari, et abdicari, vel potius abdicatum declarari posse, sed et propter externam haereseos speciem, qualis in Liberio apparuit, ob pacem cum Arianis factam, et propter subscriptionem contra Athanasium, et ob subscriptas duas confessiones Fidei, quae carebant vocabulo Homousij, et ab Arianis seu semiarianis confectae erant, licet nihil apertè contra orthodoxam fidem complecteretur. Et ex hac praesumptione de haeresi, meritò potuit ei Pontificatus abrogari, inquit Bellarminus, non enim homines tenentur, aut possunt corda scrutari, sed quem externis operibus haereticum esse vident, simpliciter haereticum iudicant, ac ut haereticum damnant. Et ex illo tempore Felix legitimus Papa factus est; qui non modo ab Arianorum communione mox recessit, sed et capita eorum, et in his ipsum Imperatorem Constantium anathemate percussit: mansitque Felix verus Pontifex</i>	<i>he fell into heresy; therefore our adversary fights with himself, says the Calvinist, when he confesses that he was deposed and yet denies that he was a heretic. I reply: those who maintain that a Pontiff, as a private person, can fall into heresy, and that Liberius did in fact fall into heresy, blow away Whitaker's objection with a single breath. But those who deny that a Pontiff, even as a private teacher, can incur heresy, and who accordingly free Liberius from every interior act of heresy, will reply that a Pontiff can be deposed — or rather deposed by God, and afterwards judged by the Church, and abdicated, or rather declared abdicated — not only for manifest, true, and real heresy, but also on account of the external appearance of heresy, such as appeared in Liberius on account of the peace made with the Arians, and on account of the subscription against Athanasius, and on account of the two confessions of Faith he subscribed, which lacked the word Homousion and had been drawn up by Arians or semi-Arians, although they contained nothing openly against the orthodox faith. And from this presumption of heresy the Pontificate could deservedly be taken from him, says Bellarmine; for men are not bound to, nor can they, search hearts; but him whom they see by external works to be a heretic, they judge simply a heretic, and condemn as a heretic. And from that time Felix was made legitimate Pope; who not only soon withdrew from the communion of the Arians, but struck their leaders — and among them the Emperor Constantius himself — with anathema: and Felix remained true Pontiff to the end of his life. For when he died, Liberius succeeded again, now changed into another man, having laid aside every guise of heresy which, serving the time, he had put on.</i>

<i>Latin (1609)</i>	<i>English</i>
usque ad finem vitae suae. Eo enim vita functo, iterum successit Liberius, iam in alium virum mutatus, deposito omni haereseos schemate, quod tempori serviens induerat.	

Col. 532 (PDF p. 309) — the Athanasius epistle and Felix's faulty entry

<i>Latin (1609)</i>	<i>English</i>
Quartò citat Bellarminus S. Athanasium, in epist. ad Felicem Papam, scriptam nomine Synodi Alexandrinae, et exstat Tomo 1. Conc. in Act. Felicis II. ubi dicit: <i>Tu es Petrus, et super fundamentum tuum Ecclesiae columnae, id est, Episcopi, sunt confirmatae.</i> Iunius, Sutlivius, Sibrandus, Witackerus, revocant in dubium fidem huius epistolae. Sed ut liquidò exploratum non sit, num haec epistola ab Athanasio et Synodo Alexandrina processerit; attamen contrarium necdum est ab ullo demonstratum: nam quod Sutlivius obiicit, <i>hanc epistolam summas tribuere laudes Felici, qui, vivente Liberio, ab Arianis in sedem Romanam intrusus fuerit</i>; id parum efficit; nam licet Felicis ingressus fuerit vitiosus; postea tamen, quando Liberius cum Arianis communicare coepit, pro legitimo Pontifice agnitus et palam habitus est, ut suo loco videbimus. Nec obstat, quòd haec epistola ait, <i>appellationes undique ad Episcopum Romanum fieri debere</i>; quia hac mente fuisse S. Athanasium, reipsa docuit, quando toties Romanae sedis opem contra hostes suos imploravit, et per appellationem ad summum Pontificem adversariorum	Fourthly, Bellarmine cites St. Athanasius, in the epistle to Pope Felix written in the name of the Synod of Alexandria (it stands in Volume 1 of the Councils, in the Acts of Felix II), where he says: <i>Thou art Peter, and upon thy foundation the pillars of the Church — that is, the Bishops — are confirmed.</i> Junius, Sutcliffe, Sibrandus, and Whitaker call the authenticity of this epistle into doubt. But even if it be not clearly ascertained whether this epistle proceeded from Athanasius and the Synod of Alexandria, still the contrary has not yet been demonstrated by anyone: for what Sutcliffe objects — <i>that this epistle bestows the highest praises on Felix, who, while Liberius lived, was intruded into the Roman see by the Arians</i> — accomplishes little; for although the entry of Felix was faulty, afterwards nevertheless, when Liberius began to communicate with the Arians, he was acknowledged and openly held as legitimate Pontiff, as we shall see in its proper place. Nor is it an obstacle that this epistle says <i>appeals from every quarter ought to be made to the Roman Bishop</i>; for that St. Athanasius was of this mind he taught in fact, when he so often implored the help of the Roman see against his enemies, and by appeal to the supreme Pontiff turned aside the machinations of his adversaries. Nor was the contrary sanctioned in the Nicene Council or the sixth African,

<i>Latin (1609)</i>	<i>English</i>
machinationes declinavit. Nec contrarium in Nicaeno et Africano sexto Concilio sancitum est; ut fingit Sutlivius: de quo infra; loco proprio.	as Sutcliffe pretends: of which below, in its proper place.

Col. 1242 (PDF p. 673) — antipopes venerated as Vicars of Christ; Junius's “public error” rejoinder

<i>Latin (1609)</i>	<i>English</i>
[The sentence opens on the facing column 1241: *... Apo]stolis Henrici IV. refert Elogia, Romanae Ecclesiae eiusque praesuli tributa, exprompsit: Neque enim schisma, ex generosis alioqui pectoribus, omnem religionis sensum dispungere poterat, praesertim accedente vexatione, quae, iuxta vetus verbum, durioribus intellectum dare* solet. Nam Henricum, et alios summam et universalem Romani Pontificis potestatem agnovisse; inde liquet, quòd legitimis Pontificibus, cum quibus gerebant inimicitias, opposuerunt <i>Antipapas</i>; quos tanquam Vicarios Christi venerabantur. An non Henricus IV. in terram prostratus suum Guibertum adoravit? In testimonio Henrici V. omittit Iunius id, quod praecipuum est, et vellicat id, quod ad rem nihil facit: Nam Bellarminus probare vult ex Imperatorum testimoniis, Romanum Pontificem esse totius Ecclesiae caput et pastorem universalem; hoc disertissimis verbis affirmat. Iunius praetersiliens, de imperiali consecratione et benedictione garrere incipit; et more suo inscitias insulasque distinctiones de vocabulo <i>Imperij et consecrationis Imperialis</i> adducit. Et tandem	[The sentence opens on the facing column:] ...he has brought out the eulogies of the apostles(?) of Henry IV, paid to the Roman Church and her prelate: for schism could not expunge every sense of religion from breasts otherwise noble, especially with vexation added, which, as the old saying goes, is wont to <i>give understanding</i> to the harder sort. For that Henry and the others acknowledged the supreme and universal power of the Roman Pontiff is clear from this: that against the legitimate Pontiffs with whom they waged their feuds they set up <i>Antipopes</i>, whom they venerated as Vicars of Christ. Did not Henry IV, prostrate on the ground, adore his own Guibert? In the testimony of Henry V, Junius omits what is principal and plucks at what is nothing to the purpose: for Bellarmine wishes to prove from the testimonies of the Emperors that the Roman Pontiff is head of the whole Church and universal pastor; this [Henry] affirms in the most explicit words. Junius, skipping past it, begins to chatter about the imperial consecration and blessing, and in his usual manner brings in ignorant and insipid distinctions about the word <i>Empire and imperial consecration</i>. And at last he flees once again to <i>public error</i>: and whatever Henry V,

<i>Latin (1609)</i>	<i>English</i>
iterum <i>ad publicum errorem</i> confugit; et quidquid Henricus V. Fridericus I. Fridericus II. in laudem Ecclesiae Romanae et Pontificis scripserunt, vel dixerunt, id <i>publico errori, et inveteratae consuetudini</i> adscribi debet. At si quid in vituperium Ecclesiae Romanae et Papae vel fecerunt, vel dixerunt; id istis merum Evangelium est, dulcius omni melle et favo.	Frederick I, and Frederick II wrote or said in praise of the Roman Church and the Pontiff must be ascribed to <i>public error and inveterate custom</i> . But if they did or said anything in disparagement of the Roman Church and the Pope, that, for these men, is pure Gospel, sweeter than any honey or honeycomb.